

John Kubiawicz (Dr Kubi) and his team at the University of California, Berkeley, are working on a huge data store called OceanStore—a part of Dr Kubi's 'introspective computing' research. Dr Kubi speaks about extending hardware and software design so that systems can continuously monitor themselves and adapt to changing circumstances. In effect, they become self-evolving

involving new ways to apply control theory and control laws, can provide insight into how to run complex systems that optimise to their environments. But autonomic computing does not require the duplication of conscious human thought as an ultimate goal.

For painless computing

The autonomic thrust has largely stemmed out of the looming shortage of people trained to manage computer systems. According to some estimates, it would take 200

million information technology workers using today's technology to support 1 billion people using computers at millions of businesses around the world. Computer firms believe it's time to make computer systems bear the cost of their own complexity, hiding it within themselves and taking responsibility for its management.

This is the crux of its Manifesto: focusing on the efficient use of silicon is not necessarily the most efficient way forward. It is aiming to bring about a world of self-managing systems and a self-managing infrastructure. "The growing complexity of the IT infrastructure threatens to undermine the very benefits information technology aims to provide. Up until now, we've relied mainly on human intervention and administration to manage this complexity," the manifesto reads, adding: "Unfortunately, we are starting to gunk up the works."

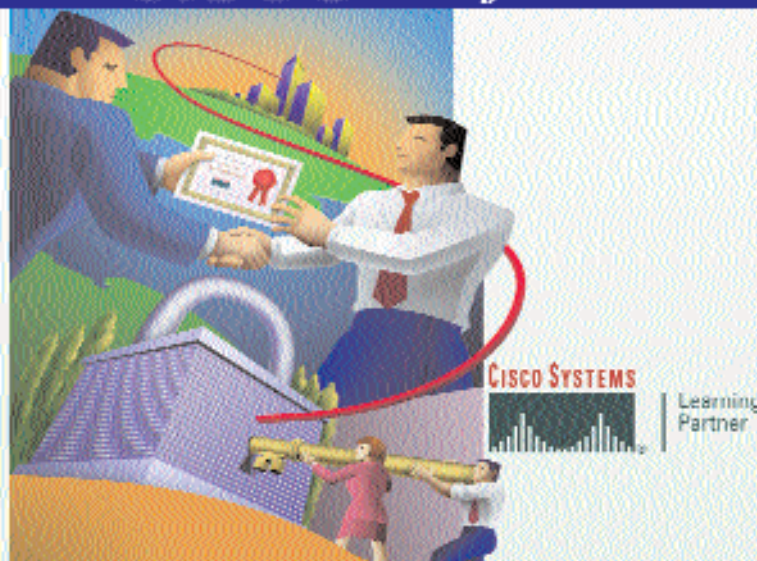
With autonomic computing, you will initially see more systems that serve you—your bank, your ISP, your travel agent. "Sorry, our systems are down" will be heard less often. Autonomic features are expected to gradually appear in client-level devices so that your individual PC will complete for itself many of the tasks that currently make you a part-time administrator.

According to the Meta Group, the real challenge to get these processors to work together is software. Extending capabilities that exist on one platform to others and defining system management identities and relationships are some of the major hurdles to autonomic computing.

What's the future of autonomic computing? Says Purdy, "One clear area is the wireless realm where autonomic processes will help maintain our future cell phones as they become more data centric. We'll also see the concept of 'live update' extended to 'over-the-air' synchronisation, thus allowing our contacts and appointments to be kept up to date as we roam about. We'll also see more home and office systems connected to outside information resources so that monitoring and maintenance of our physical infrastructure will occur within the next 25 years. In a way, we'll begin to view the systems around us as more intelligent and reliable."

The challenge of personal autonomic computing is to simplify and enhance the end-user experience. Computing, as dictated by this concept, should be able to delight the user by anticipating their needs. One only hopes that the concept becomes real and not just an overblown dream. ■

LESLIE D'MONTE



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